

sands of Indians are being introduced to the PC every day. By exposing first-time users to OSS, they can be free from the monetary hassles of Proprietary Software (PS)—or the legal implications of pirating it, as we said. Additionally, besides reducing the total cost of the PC, OSS also allows customisation to suit the needs of every linguistic group in every state of India. Altering the user interface to the local language will greatly increase acceptance of the PC.

While OSS can be modified using local expertise (with or without government funding, since it is for social benefit), PS alterations need to be done by the vendor, which is usually influenced by economic considerations, like the size of the market. If a native of Assam needs to appreciate the power of the PC, the interface needs to be in Assamese. Given the small size of that population, the chances that PS will be available in the local language are very slim. But an OSS can be modified by locals to suit their needs.

Before we continue further, the following terms need to be clarified.

1.2 The Open Source Movement

1.2.1 What Is OSS ?

OSS literally means software whose source is open. Stretching this definition, to be termed OSS, the software should also not restrict the user from freely using it, modifying it and distributing it. The most significant differences between OSS and Proprietary Software (PS) are immediately apparent. PS is usually distributed as a binary without the source code. So it is almost impossible to dissect the program to learn about its structure and logic, and make corrections or modifications if necessary. PSS is normally sold with a lot of conditions that restrict the usage and distribution of the program.

1.2.2 What OSS Isn't

There is a general opinion that all OSS is also free of cost. That isn't the case. Proponents of OSS do not restrict the sale of the OSS. People are free to package and sell OSS at a price they consider fit.